Calling it the Mahendragiri test complex is a misnomer. And this cost us some bad publicity from some overzealous environmentalists, which we will come to later. The test complex today stands by the valley of the Podigai hill, south of Mahendragiri, north of which stood the Kadukkaraithodu. The forest between Mahendragiri and Kadukkaraithodu was home to the endangered lion-tailed monkey, which became a subject for a baseless, short campaign against the test complex.

Once the ISRO board approved Mahendragiri (let's call it that, for that's the name it is known by), our job was cut out. We had to acquire some 7,000 acres, of which 600 acres were in private hands and the rest government forest land that spread across the two south Tamil Nadu districts of Tirunelveli and Kanyakumari. This was not an easy task as taking over private property was riddled with legal hassles, and getting forest land transferred meant navigating bureaucratic rigmaroles.

The Tirunelveli collector, Shanmugham, showed great interest in the project, even trekking the hills with us several times for surveys and talks with villagers. He put the revenue divisional officer and two tahsildars at my disposal. Whenever the tahsildars raised opposition, I asked them to put it on paper. Most of the times, they did not persist, as there was no case beyond some personal reasons.

The Kanyakumari officials tried to delay things. I asked one of the revenue officials why they were not as cooperative with ISRO as their Tirunelveli counterparts. He said that the district authorities were proud to have an ISRO facility, but they thought all credit would go to Tirunelveli district since the main entrance of the test complex was from Tirunelveli district, though major tracts of land fell on the Kanyakumari side. So much for bureaucratic pride!

Acquiring the forest land was not much of a problem though it involved multiple clearances, but we had to do it without offending the neighbouring villagers. There were two sections of villagers who were concerned. One was involved in destroying the forest. Entering the forest in the name of collecting fallen twigs for firewood, they had been chopping and carting away full grown trees. The other group had a more noble purpose to visit